

# Ten endings that explain. Twenty-three that don't.

Every chapter's final paragraph, judged by one rule: does it end the story or explain it?

Most of the book already ends clean — earlier passes did that work. These ten are what's left. Each card shows the current ending, the reason, and what the chapter's last line becomes. Tick to approve.

## FACT QUESTION FIRST

Ch 6

"Dave went on to play in the NFL, then became a missionary in China..."

The new praise page and Afterword credit Dave as former Captain, Virginia Tech Football — his own wording. Chapter 6 says he played in the NFL. Did he actually play in the NFL after Virginia Tech, or not? One of these is wrong about a real person, in print.

## CUT

Ch 5 · The Man Who Raised Me

"It took me years to see what he had handed me. I make my living showing up... Everything I do at a bedside, I first learned in his car."

The bedside-bridge moral — and Chapter 3 already ends on the same move. Twice in three chapters.

**NEW ENDING** "As much as his own. He didn't soften it. I believed him."



## CUT

Ch 9 · They'll Teach You

"That was the man who adopted me. He never talked about himself... I was proud to be his son."

Summarizes the chapter the reader just finished. The paragraph above it ends inside the joke.

**NEW ENDING** "...keeping a straight face, waiting for you to fall for it."

## CUT

Ch 18 · The Quiet Years

"People asked why I did all of it... staying sober wasn't the boring part. It was the whole victory."

The moral, stated. The paragraph before it already lands the same truth as an image.

☐ **NEW ENDING** "Nobody would make a movie out of it."

## TRIM

Ch 3 · The Man Who Didn't Have To

"I get it now. I didn't back then. I see it every day at work... For me, it started on a Saturday. With a bucket of baseballs."

The bedside explanation belongs to one chapter, not two (see Ch 5). The closing image is the keeper.

**NEW ENDING** "I get it now. I didn't back then. For me, it started on a Saturday. With a bucket of baseballs."

**TRIM**

Ch 6 • The Wrestler

“...He’s the one who wrote the afterword to this book. That tells you who he is.”

“That tells you who he is” tells the reader what to conclude. The facts already do it.

☐ **NEW ENDING** the sentence ends at “...wrote the afterword to this book.”

**TRIM**

Ch 11 • MTV

“Miami changed my life, and the man who made it possible was sharing a rental in Mahwah...”

“Miami changed my life” is the verdict; the loans, the rental, and the caps are the evidence. Lead with the evidence.

**NEW ENDING** “The man who made it possible was sharing a rental in Mahwah, paying back loans for years, never once making the cost feel like something I owed him. I graduated in May 2000... California beckoned.”

**TRIM**

Ch 19 • The People You Meet

“I started sober thinking mediocrity was the ceiling. Then I met Andy, Bob, Mager, Matt, and Quint...”

☐ that turned out to be the whole thing.”

Recaps five portraits the reader just read, and “the whole thing” is the tic we’ve been cutting. The Hope tease is worth keeping — it’s a door, not a moral.

**NEW ENDING** “...I believed there was more for me to do than stay alive. And the best one didn’t come from a meeting at all. You’ll meet her soon.”

**TRIM**

Ch 21 • They Gave Me a Chance

“...My manager Brenda Jahn was one of the best I ever worked for. She believed in me and pushed me, and that prepared me for everything that came next.”

The chapter’s true ending is three sentences earlier — the car, the paperwork, “This was enough.” Brenda reads as acknowledgments; she has a home there.

**NEW ENDING** “They gave me a chance, and I stayed ten years.”

**TRIM**

Ch 23 • The Salmon Palace

“...From a one-bedroom salmon castle to a house we built from the ground up. That’s what five years of quiet, unglamorous work can do.”

☐ The castle-to-house line IS the point. The last sentence repeats it as a lesson.

**NEW ENDING** “From a one-bedroom salmon castle to a house we built from the ground up.”

“...I don’t say that for sympathy. I say it because it’s the truth, and this book doesn’t work if I only tell the parts where I got it right.”

The confession is strong. The sentence defending the confession is the book talking about itself.



**NEW ENDING** “...Hospice, when it came, wasn’t a pivot. It was a return... It pulled me out of that in-between place and gave me direction again.” (cut only the “I don’t say that for sympathy” pair)

## Already ending clean — no action

Ch 1 (the airport, the wrong words) · Ch 2 (“someone she wanted us to meet”) · Ch 4 (the alphabet line) · Ch 7 (the marks, earned) · Ch 8 (the front door) · Ch 10 (the waitress) · Ch 12 (“The elevator was still going down”) · Ch 13 (“Please, finish me off”) · Ch 14 (“got me alone”) · Ch 15 (“It kept me alive”) · Ch 16 (the surrender) · Ch 17 (ordinary mornings) · Ch 20 (the Tuesday coffee) · Ch 22 (the dismissals) · Ch 24 (“kept calling / kept coming”) · Ch 25 (trimmed earlier today) · Ch 26 (“Hope floated”) · Ch 27 (the tribute to your mother — a chosen address, not a moral) · Ch 29 (“A Thursday.”) · Ch 30 (the gray suit) · Ch 31 (the first honest mile) · Ch 32 (“I’m trying to do the same”) · Ch 33 (the morning call — the closing chapter has earned its reflection)